

The Self and Beyond It

An Essay on Fullness and Transcendence

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Preface

Presumptuousness is a two-faced trait. On the one hand, anyone who encounters presumptuousness in another person reacts with revulsion and inner resistance. On the other hand, without a respectable measure of presumptuousness, people would never dare, would never break through, and many significant and useful things would never have come into the world, but would have been shelved before their birth.

In this essay I intend to propose a presumptuous move. The move proposes a point of view according to which one can find, in the human soul, two foundational strivings, deep layers, which drive a person in most of his belongings, deeds, experiences, quests and longings. The vectors of these foundational strivings are opposite in direction, and yet I will propose both of them, and support both with explanations and examples. The final chapter of the essay will be devoted to the question of the relation between the two pictures.[1]

Let me add one further comment. It is important to understand that when I speak of a "foundational striving," I do not mean some particular force of will, one among many, standing alongside the other wills. We feel our ordinary wills clearly and distinctly, each will pointing us toward the action it drives us to perform and toward the objects that will satisfy its aim. When I define, here, a "foundational striving" — fullness or transcendence — I mean to speak of a plane that, schematically, precedes the plane of our actual wills; I mean to define a foundational stratum in the structure of the soul. My intention will be better understood if the essay is taken to belong not necessarily (or: not only) to the field of psychology, but also, and more so, to the field of ontology.

A. Fullness

"If I am not for myself, who will be for me?" (Avot 1:14)

1. Defining the Concept

The first striving I will discuss is the striving for a state and feeling of inner fullness.[2] A state of fullness is a state in which a person feels that his identity and his happiness exist stably, without leaning on anything external, but out of the person's own selfhood. He is whole with what he is; his lacks are filled from the inner spring that exists within him, the spring that is, in fact, himself. His self-definition is complete and closed. His certainty in his powers, in the meaning of his life and in his uniqueness, and his joy in being who he is, exist

by their own force, and not because of some reason that must be sought outside. Fullness can be defined negatively as follows: a person of fullness is a person who has no essential need for anything outside himself, a person who has no dependency on any person, factor or object that is not himself.

It is important to explain that when I speak of a lack of need for what is outside him, I do not mean that such a person does not make use of society's services, does not deal and exchange with others, and is not helped, does not open up, and does not receive advice. A person need not be gifted in every talent, and need not be closed off or indifferent to social interface with his surroundings, in order to be considered a person of fullness. The lack of need is found on the basic psychic plane of the sense of self-worth. I may feel lonely, I will certainly feel pain if society pushes me outside its circle, and there are certainly needs and wants within me that pertain to things beyond my control. But even very difficult feelings, like pain, loneliness, insult, and so on, can be experienced from a solid place, from an anchored existence. The question is whether the person is liable to feel himself blown about by the wind, like one gone mad on a rudderless ship — whether what happens to him in the external territory of his life, in his relation to his friends, to his financial state, to his standing in the eyes of others, and so on, takes from him the basic anchor of his will to live and his love of life, throwing him into a state of chaos and confusion, in which he has no fortified island of stability and security on which to plant his feet.

2. The Foundations of Fullness

Before we consider the implications of the fact that all of us lack fullness, and the complexes and oddities to which this lack leads us, let us deepen the definition of the concept by analyzing its components — that is, the foundations from which it is built. If we mark them with code names, one could say that fullness is composed of three foundations — worth, purpose, and humility.

Worth — the sense of fullness is built on the basis of a recognition of the unqualified worth of the self. The healthy, instinctive state, in which a person wants his life at any price, translates itself into a clearer and more comprehensive conception of the state of being alive as a fitting state, a conception that my being is preferable to my not-being, that is, that my being is something right, correct and desirable. A basic consciousness that accompanies him all his days, at the bottom of awareness, is the consciousness of his own worth — not because of something he does, and not because of some particular way he behaves, not for this or that purpose, and therefore also not subject to any condition or qualification — the very fact of his existence is a thing that carries importance. This self-importance is experienced not as a subjective whim, not as some particular person's attitude, but as a real, objective matter. It is not merely that I say I am worthy, not merely that I think I am worthy, not merely that I hear from others that I am worthy; I am worthy, period.

Originally, the source of the sense of self-worth is the love a person absorbed from his parents since birth. For the infant's parents, as his primary and total environment, have a decisive influence on the healthy development of his psychic health. They instill in him their

love, the concern they feel for him, and their total devotion to his existence and his welfare. In this way, a person grows up when his consciousness is born out of a reality in which the fact that he is important and worthy is a self-evident, objective and unconditional reality. This source does not depend on a person's choice, but on his good fortune, on the question of who bore and raised him, and how. It seems that other, cognitive sources should be proposed, by which a person, out of his own consciousness, will and choice, establishes for himself the sense of self-worth.[3]

Worth can be grounded in the understanding that the fact that I was created attests to a divine will for my existence — and specifically for my existence, for my particular character and my specific traits. Each morning upon waking we say the Modeh Ani prayer, in which we acknowledge with gratitude that God chose to restore us to life — "I thank You, living and enduring King, for You have mercifully restored my soul within me" — and we conclude it: "great is Your faithfulness." If we continue to exist, if our lives continue to be a fact, this itself testifies to the great faith God places in us. Surely this is so from the outset as well — if we are here, if we were created, this involves a supreme will, a heavenly decision; it is a sign that this whole, this "I," which is a one-time, unique whole, belonging exclusively to me alone, is a good, upright, correct and fitting thing. Something in me differs significantly from every other human being on earth, and this difference is significant enough that it justifies, in the eyes of the Creator of the world, my creation, my addition to the sum of existing humanity. The Holy One has signed off on my uniqueness.

By contrast, one can establish a sense of worth without resting it on religious faith. This is a way whose exact workings on the level of consciousness are hard to explain, since it mainly concerns activity on a prior plane. A person leaps into an enthusiastic self-acceptance. This is an act of courage and of forceful inner resolve — the resolve that I love myself, and that I accept this love fully, and the belief that this love is more foundational than anything that comes against it. Every faintness of spirit and every doubt about self-worth is grasped as a more external plane attacking the person from without, while, within him, this campaign is closed and settled, and the "I" is whole with itself. This is a stance of determination facing reality, facing existence — if this is what there is, then this is what ought to be; if this is who I am, then it is good for me to be so.[4]

Purpose — purpose expresses the presence of the feeling that my life has an aim. If the sense of worth concerns the "I" as a static entity, as a fixed being whose existence lies before us and whose quality we judge as it is, then purpose is centered on the "I" as a moving and active factor, as an entity that is continually coming into being, as something whose essence is determined and formed as it actualizes itself along the axis of time. Even a person who has worth in his own eyes, and who does not fall into the bitterness of self-hatred, still needs to establish, for his life, a sense of direction, to produce for himself a value-based and existential compass that will steer the ship of his life toward some real destination and that will grant his life meaning. Without purpose, fullness cannot be attained.

A person builds his purpose for himself. A person whose sense of purpose is strong is a person who clarifies for himself the correct path in life, and decides to make the utmost

effort to live as he believes it is fitting to live. To this end, a person seeks and selects for himself a worldview and an ideology, and chooses and discovers the values he wants to actualize, the goals he wishes to achieve, and the trends he wants to advance. A life that advances in light of a certain direction — spiritual, moral, religious or ideological — and actualizes what, in the person's eyes, is the good, correct and most pleasant way to live, is a life that contains the foundational seed of happiness. The events of life stand outside the fortress of this foundational happiness, since the essence of a person's sense of wholeness lies in the way he responds, in his choices, and in the ways he navigates in order to cope with what life offers.

A person with worth but without purpose will fall into emptiness. In such a state, the heightened sense of self-worth actually sharpens and intensifies the existential crisis of a lack of direction in life, since it amplifies the inner feeling that I have so much potential for good and light wanting to actualize and burst forth from potentiality into actuality, and this potential is missed, choked and withers within me, since I do not know where to direct it, what to do with it, and how to guide its path into reality. The bewilderment surrounding the question of how to translate the inner light that is the depth of the "I" into ways of living leads to a frustration that intensifies the emptiness and the despair.

From the other direction, one could say that purpose requires worth as a precondition, since, in order to choose a way of life, a faith and a scale of values, a person must believe in himself that he has the capacity to discern the truth and to choose the correct paths of life. When the "I" that chooses the path is not important enough, not honored enough, not worthy enough — the meaning of the path is weakened, its certainty cracks, and its ability to serve as an anchor and a compass crumbles. An extreme state in which a person nonetheless has strong purpose but no worth is the state found in cults and totalitarian parties of various kinds, a state in which a person is drawn after a defined, clear and unambiguous system of values that someone else — a political leader, a guru, or some other charismatic person — defines, and demands submission and obedience to.[5]

Fullness is built only on the basis of worth and purpose together. For we defined fullness as a state of not needing anything found outside the person. The person aspires that his existential anchor be lodged in himself alone. Worth and purpose are each responsible for a different layer of self-wholeness and of independence: worth prevents the person from writhing in self-society complexes around the subject of image and honor. It slakes our need to feel that we are "worth something" without our having to knock, thirsting, on the doors of social recognition of us, and thereby grants us true freedom, independence and authenticity. Purpose, by contrast, guards against complexes formed on the axis of the pursuit of happiness, meaning and significance. It is the healthy, independent and stable way of supplying the foundational need to feel a taste in our lives, and when we do not supply this tremendous inner demand from within ourselves, it gropes its way in the dark, and is pushed to bind us to low and random sparks of pleasure.

The union of worth and purpose builds fullness not only in the negative sense of the negation of dependency, but also in the positive, affirmative sense. Fullness is a feeling of

joy in oneself, of deep satisfaction in what I have within me. Of course, this "I" in which I rejoice appears and is embodied mainly in actual life, and the standard for judging and assessing myself lies on the concrete, practical plane. Therefore, joy in oneself depends both on one's relation to the "I" as an object, as a sum of traits and virtues, features and characteristics, and on one's relation to the active, choosing, living "I"; I must be satisfied not only with what I am by nature, but also with the way of life I choose, with the values I believe in, with the opinions I hold. In other words, fullness requires that I have an inwardness with content, an inwardness I can look upon and rejoice in. This content can be divided into two: the innate-given, and the elective-emergent. Worth colors the first part in a positive hue, while purpose illuminates the second.

Humility — at first glance, humility and fullness stand at exactly opposite poles. Yet, precisely because of this, humility is essential for creating a true and successful fullness. As in the economy of tevel (untithed produce), it is precisely the relinquishment and setting-aside of part of the crop that "repairs" it and makes it fit. I use the concept of humility here in a broader sense than usual, and in order to explain my intention I must elaborate somewhat. Although this may seem to deviate from the course of the essay, these words will clarify and illuminate the concept of fullness in a new and refined light. I will give a few sketches of humility, or of its absence.

1.

Six years you shall sow your field, and six years you shall prune your vineyard, and gather in its produce. But in the seventh year there shall be a sabbath of solemn rest for the land, a sabbath unto the LORD; you shall not sow your field, nor prune your vineyard. That which grows of its own accord of your harvest you shall not reap, nor gather the grapes of your undressed vine; it shall be a year of solemn rest for the land.

Leviticus 25:3–5

Six years you shall sow your land, and gather in its produce; but the seventh year you shall let it rest and lie fallow, that the poor of your people may eat; and what they leave the beasts of the field shall eat. In like manner you shall deal with your vineyard and with your olive grove.

Exodus 23:10–11

Let us examine the commandment of the Sabbatical year from an existential point of view: the tiller of the soil, who for six years brings forth his bread by the sweat of his brow, and who is bound to his land and its yield by a bond of toil and labor, is commanded to observe a year of release. He sees before his eyes the aftergrowth of the harvest, the grapes growing in his vineyard, and access to them is withheld from him; he is forbidden to gather them, to claim them as his own. His ownership is suspended, and he opens the gates of the field and the vineyard to all who come. This is a special movement of withdrawal — precisely from that very thing you toil over, that you pursue to acquire and increase, to render fruitful and

to gather all the years, precisely from it you are commanded to withdraw your hand, to relinquish.[6]

2. We are all familiar with the phenomenon of pressuring parents. Somewhere in the stages of adolescence, a growing friction breaks out between the child's spreading wings of independence and the parents' worry and enveloping care. Even if, during adolescence, this is not always how it looks, it is easy to sympathize with the parents. Their love for the tender fruit of their womb, which for many long years led them to attend to his every need and to carry the full burden of his existence on their shoulders, must suddenly take on an entirely different form. And indeed, many parents fail to make this consciousness- and emotion-based transformation in time, on their own, without pressure and pushing "from below," from the direction of the son who demands his independence and his freedom, his self-definition as separate from them. And even when the pressure does appear, and even when the time is right for it and the son is already mature enough, there are parents who are unable to step back even a little, to loosen the rope, and who continue to interrogate him about his deeds and his outings, to try to restrict him or pressure him through educational or emotional means, to be involved in his life and his daily routine beyond what he truly needs. The ability to release the suffocating embrace, the ability to understand that the fibers of life that bind the parent to his child continue to exist with force even within a mature and enabling relationship, the ability to let go of the need to be the exclusive and determining presence in the child's life — this is the capacity for humility.

3. In the streets of the great city we find the person in a hurry. The pace of his walk attests to the pace of his life, in which he tries to seize as much as possible within the crowded time frame that the twenty-four-hour day grants him. A characteristic component of the life of this kind of modern person is the concept of the "agenda" or the "schedule." One who lives his life around the clock cannot step into a day that contains a chaotic collection of tasks and vital actions; he must organize his day around defined hours, pouring planning and order into the stream of time. What place will surprises, the "unplanned events,"[7] occupy in his life? How will he cope with events that stray beyond the horizon of his planning? What attitude will be granted to a person who delays him or asks him for a sudden allotment of his time?

The more stressed type will react with irritation, with impatience, even with anger. Departure from the planned order gives him the feeling that he is losing his critical control over his life, over the precious treasure of his time. By contrast, there are those who, despite their busy and energetic schedule, know how to receive, with a warm countenance and a smile, the small (and near-inevitable) deviations that fate sends their way, whether it is a stuck elevator, traffic congestion, or a friend requesting urgent help. They know that one cannot grasp and control the full expanse of time, and, in their humility, they succeed in letting go of the desperation of this total effort, in giving vital room to rebellious territories of time that do not accept the authority of humanly planned conquest.

4. "I have a serious psychiatric disorder," my friend admitted with a smile, when I asked him the reason he was still sitting in the same position he had been sitting in four hours earlier,

his hands still polishing the block of wood he had carved and prepared for his girlfriend. "It's called perfectionism." The artist, the musician, the painter, the writer — in short, anyone whose hands are engaged in creation — all know the perfectionist phenomenon. Some demanding striving for a perfection that knows no satiety, some conquering drive to continue, again and again, to refine, to improve, to renovate, to correct, this task of yours that you were supposed to have finished long ago. And indeed, "perfectionist" is not necessarily a term of abuse. Much genius has come into the world through those meticulous artists who let the drive for perfection conquer them and rule their spirit. And yet, with a delicate eye, one can see the excessive, "sickly," aberrant places to which the tendency and the wish to bring things to their optimum, to reach the summit of perfection and precision, lead us — while this infinite goal continues to recede from our grasp and forces us to invest time and strength that ought properly to go elsewhere. The possibility of actualizing an idea, and being satisfied with the actual result even though it is necessarily lesser and more blurred relative to its spiritual-theoretical source, depends on the existence of humility.

Let us now return to the accepted meaning of the concept of humility, a meaning that belongs to the domain of a person's self-relation to his traits, his virtues and his shortcomings. Humility is the capacity to stand before my flaws and shortcomings with eyes wide open. We must internalize the fact that we are not whole, and, more than that — at bottom, our incompleteness is the fitting state of affairs, and is a good thing. It opens for us gates of effort and of labor, of advancement and of repair — and it is by these that we live. The courageous striving for perfection and self-improvement is supported by the humility that limits it, that sets before it the picture of reality and does not allow it to slip away into fantasies and illusions. The humble person runs forward, but he also knows how to fall. The fall does not throw him off the track; the shortcomings and flaws do not cast him out of the basic self-love vital for all spiritual work.

It is now clear what the connection is between humility and fullness. Fullness strives to fill the person, to pour positive content into him, so that the person may have a stance against what lies outside him while relying on himself alone. The person acquires a positive outlook on himself, and strives to line his life with good, with the doing of good and the striving for good. It is precisely this attempt, precisely this grip on the picture of fullness — which must be a firm grip, since it comes to anchor the person's place and his self-definition — precisely this must be crowned with the crown of humility, must learn the movement of letting go. We want to be perfect, and we want to actualize the good in our lives, but sometimes we do not succeed in this, even when we try and strive with all our might. In order not to fall into despair and bitterness, in order not to give up entirely on this vital presumption, we need a gaze of humility, a lighter place within us that accepts imperfection with a certain triviality, a place of self-humor that preserves the correct perspective regarding the inexhaustible attempt to succeed and win only victories. A person who has worth and purpose but no humility will be an ambitious, advancing, conquering person (in the positive sense), but one with a constant inner hunger liable to overtake his judgment. Only fullness and humility together bring about a deep, sincere and sober satisfaction.[8]

One can note that humility is not only a condition for the complete existence of fullness, but also the reverse — fullness psychically enables humility. When I have a psychic anchor in the good within me, when I am filled with confidence in the positive character of my inner essence and of the content of my life, then I am free to look, piercingly and impartially, at the sides of deficiency and flaw within me, and at my failure to actualize the good in every circumstance. I have no need for self-deception, since the point of stability, of psychic equilibrium, has long since been given, and cannot be dislodged by this or that hard fact. It follows, then, that humility and fullness are different sides of the same coin, different aspects of the same complex and healthy psychic reality, which enables contentment and joy.

3. Complications and Implications

Since complete fullness is something that almost never exists, the worlds of complex are far more familiar to us than the worlds of self-fullness. "Complex" is, on the face of it, too strong and harsh a term, but we will do better if we clear it, for a moment, of pathological, aberrant connotations. "Complex," as a translation of the term Complex, essentially expresses a structure of complexity. Our whole lives are full of such and other complexes, since no person undergoes a perfect experience, no one actualizes all his powers, drives and desires in a clean, clear, simple and straight way. No human being begins under perfect circumstances, and no one copes perfectly with his life. Complexes — that is, the contortions and metamorphoses our basic psychic forces undergo as a result of hard circumstances and flawed coping — are an inseparable and even normal part of our human lives.

In this section I wish — in condensed form, in hints and headings — to demonstrate and illustrate the centrality of the concept of fullness as defined here, to show the many and varied implications of its absence, and thereby to point to its importance. We have already mentioned some of these complexes briefly in what has been said so far, but we will nonetheless include them in the list here.

Fawning and flattery — this is, of course, a direct and expected result of the absence of fullness. A person needs some instrument or means to establish his own certainty in himself and his sense of worth in his life, and, since he does not find this within, he searches for it desperately without. Because of this he is willing to devote himself to someone strong who gives him a bit of room and attention, and even appreciation, even if this is not sincere appreciation, and even if the person himself is not at peace with the figure before whom he has chosen to fawn, and with the deeds for which he earns this appreciation. The concept of "flattery," too, is a concept that, in our ordinary language, is attributed to more extreme and conspicuous situations,[9] and here too one can discern finer and more common gradations. Even subjugation to a group of people and their collective thoughts — whether these are declared-ideological, covert-social, or aesthetic-fashionable — falls into the same psychic slot in which I writhe and falsify myself in order to earn approval from without; even subtle conformism is a branch of flattery.

Arrogance, competitiveness, envy — every way in which a person highlights and externalizes his advantages (real or imagined) over his other and his environment is a distorted way of obtaining approval and a (counterfeit) sense of fullness. Here, the external approval is granted not by society, but by the objectivity of the plane of comparison in the eyes of the arrogant person, an objectivity that helps him feel his own uniqueness and worth even when he is, ostensibly, by himself. Competitiveness stems from this very same outlook, except that, for those it produces, the absence of purpose is also added, turning competitiveness itself into a central and highly powerful driving force,[10] not only because of the need for approval of one's personal worth, but also because of the need for meaning and a reason to live, to want, and to strive.[11] Arrogant self-elevation and envy are two sides of the same sorry oscillation upon the shaky comparative-objective basis. Here too, arrogance can be dressed in more subtle garments, such as, for instance, people who step into the shoes of colorful social figures like the tormented, complicated and lonely artist, or, alternatively, the provocative nonconformist, not out of a true reflection of their inner world but out of a wish to display and create their uniqueness above everyone else.

Self-pity — self-pity is often described in literature as a kind of warm, sticky quicksand into which a person is tempted to let himself fall. This is the sweetness within bitterness, a feeling according to which despair and total surrender burn to such a degree that they bring about a refinement, a sense of release that is almost delightful. Release from the ceaseless effort invested in the struggle to win, to advance, to be beautiful or good or successful. Self-pity comes from a place of failure. On the face of it, coping with our failure to be what we want to be can lead in only two directions, seemingly — a mustering of strength and setting out for another round of struggle, or, alternatively, once strength has run out, surrender and despair, a self-sinking into pity.[12] Fullness, together with the humility bound up with it, creates a gap between these two exclusive possibilities, and weaves within it a third possibility, a third space. A space in which one can linger and dwell, even if only temporarily, together with failure. Of course, failure stings and is unpleasant, and of course we feel compelled to remove it from ourselves; but by virtue of the firm point of certainty that the person of fullness has regarding himself, and by virtue of the humility that enables him to accept his imperfection honestly and soberly, other possibilities of response open before him, ones that do not require a mustering of strength and an immediate return to the circle of effort, but also do not cast him into a bottomless pit — possibilities such as: crying out, or mourning, or self-humor.

Materialism, addictions and emptiness — one who lacks fullness, and especially one who has not built his own purpose, moves through life without a clear compass to guide him. Of course we all have innate instincts and drives, and, among these, various and diverse wills that constantly send us toward different tasks and in all sorts of directions. But since a person is a conscious and choosing creature, he will, in the end, need some navigator, some method or outlook by which to guide himself coherently and meaningfully. Like a kind of overarching program that sorts and gives instructions for how to implement and how to rank the full set of tasks assigned to the computer. Human consciousness turns the arbitrariness of the collection of instinctive wills into something meaningless, and this

meaninglessness into an existential distress, such that although a person is always moving and acting, he feels an emptiness[13] as long as he fails to explain to himself what gives all this scurrying about a meaning, a purpose and a justification.

Like the physical vacuum phenomenon, emptiness too draws inward, with great force, foreign factors from everything accessible to it. The most basic, simple and understandable human wills are material wills; and so a state of lacking purpose naturally leads to a hedonistic approach to life, in which the person who holds it fills the slot of the inner navigator with the pursuit of physical pleasure, and clings to this pursuit as his life's task in order to rescue himself from emptiness, even if it does not accord with the fine threads of moral intuition and spiritual longing. In a similar way, one should describe the dynamic of the phenomenon of addiction, and every kind of addiction in the broadest sense:[14] the person avoids clarifying and building his own purpose, and therefore also flees from renewed clarifications regarding the de facto method by which his life is being conducted. Emptiness feeds into the inner navigator the behaviors it already knows, habitual behaviors remembered as somewhat satisfying, and the person prefers to hold devoutly to that same behavior rather than rationally examine its place against his other, repressed preferences, so as not to be exposed to the confusion and arbitrariness that characterize his march through life.[15] This can explain our lack of rationality when we become addicted, and continue to do things we understand are not good for us and are sometimes even harmful.

Cowering fear of Heaven — in the religious field, fullness takes shape as a foundational starting point according to which the Holy One created the individual person out of love and trust. Without such a starting point, religiosity can become a weakening and depressing factor, and the overall experience of my standing before God will be grasped as self-nullification and dependency, rather than being grasped as an experience that comes to refine, to empower and to sanctify my character. Sadly, the religious world often bears such a face in the eyes of its critics — a face of a lack of independence and of leaning on authority figures on the plane of life decisions; a face of fear, guilt and panic before the weight of the obligation to fulfill a heavenly decree down to every last detail of its specific demands; a face of self-diminishment and of passivity perceived as praiseworthy traits of humility and trust; and so on.

Against such a religious world, the religious world of one who has internalized that he possesses essential and unique worth — and not only this, but that the one who grants him this worth, in His love, His mercy and His faithfulness, is God Himself, who created man in His own image — will paint the existing concepts in an entirely different set of colors. Humility will include the recognition of the tremendous divine potential embedded in the human soul; trust will call upon the person to act and to have self-confidence, together with the boldness to be a "partner with God"; remorse and repentance will bring about a deep faith in a person's ability to repair what has been done and to rebuild his character from the ground up; Gehinnom and the concepts of punishment will be grasped as the soul's infernal suffering, arising naturally from the distance from the divine Eden the soul longs for with all its strength, such that "the punishment for sin is sin" itself; the obligation to keep Torah and

mitzvot will take shape as a loving fidelity and a moral commitment that a person enters into through active engagement, "accepting the yoke of the kingdom of Heaven." In sum — it is indeed true that submission and limitation constitute highly significant components of religiosity, and it sees part of its essential role as restraining a person's animal power and blocking the wings of his will as they spread in every direction. But one who builds his picture of the world on a psychic basis of self-confidence and fullness, and on a faith-based basis of the Creator's love for His creature, cannot establish a world in which, at the heart of the matter, a person feels that the divine being and its infinite power stand against him, bowing him to the ground and working weakness and emptiness upon him. The foundational picture will be that the divine being directs its power toward raising, sanctifying and elevating humanity from its primal earthly rank to the highest heavens of the divine spark at the root of its being.

B. Transcendence

"And when I am for myself, what am I?" (Avot, ibid.)

1. Opening

The second foundational striving, which dwells in the human heart with force and depth, I have called by the name Transcendence. The outlook that allows us to see, in transcendence, a comprehensive foundational stratum of the soul requires a different perspective than the one taken so far to highlight fullness. In vague, abstract and obscure words — words that should be taken as a preface and a rough sketch, and which I hope will become clearer, more grounded, and take on reality and substance as I unpack and break them down into various and many-hued manifestations — it seems one should define the psychic force in question as follows:

Within a person there is a need to break out beyond himself. Within us nests an ex-self drive, an inner necessity to turn toward some object found outside the circle of selfhood, and to bind one's life to it. A need to attach, to turn, to break out of the shell, to burst from the "I" into a foreign territory, a territory of "otherness," of the other, of some "thing" that is not only within me. The person seeks a point of anchorage that will lie beyond himself, and will thereby rescue his being. Without the satisfaction of transcendence, without attachment to some matter found outside the circle of egoistic-natural-material existence, our lives sink into boredom, loneliness, rootlessness, meaninglessness,[16] and, in effect, life withers and degenerates in its own eyes.

If fullness can be pictured as a vector pointing inward, whose whole concern is to negate the person's reliance on the outside and to leave him standing on his own alone, then transcendence must be described in exactly the opposite way — a vector that always points outward.[17] This vector breaks down into various wills, belonging to different and seemingly unconnected domains of the soul, though I am not trying to argue that all these wills are experienced — on the felt, familiar plane — as belonging to one shared inner will,

but rather that, in "philosophical" language, or on the ontological level, they can be grasped as such.

2. Existential Separateness — Erich Fromm

In his highly successful book *The Art of Loving*, Erich Fromm defines the foundational problem of human existence with a term he invents and coins — existential separateness. Separateness is the experience that we are uprooted, that we are cut off, that we sway like a lone leaf in the world without being bound to and supported by someone or something outside us. This is an unbearable state, and the person seeks every possible way to escape it.

At the moment a human being — or the human race — is born, cast out of a state which was as definite as instincts are, into a state of indefiniteness, uncertainty, openness... man is endowed with reason; he is life aware of itself... This awareness of himself as a separate entity, the awareness of his own short life span, of the fact that without his will he is born and against his will he dies, that he will die before those he loves, or they before him, the awareness of his aloneness and separateness, of his helplessness before the forces of nature and of society, all this makes his separate, disunited existence an unbearable prison. He would become insane could he not liberate himself from this prison and reach out, unite himself in some form or other with men, with the world outside.

The experience of separateness arouses anxiety; it is, indeed, the source of all anxiety. Being separate means being cut off, without any capacity to use my human powers. Hence to be separate means to be helpless, unable to grasp the world — things and people — actively; it means that the world can invade me without my ability to react. Thus, separateness is the source of intense anxiety.

[...]

The deepest need of man, then, is the need to overcome his separateness, to leave the prison of his aloneness. The absolute failure to achieve this aim means insanity...

Man — of all ages and cultures — is confronted with the solution of one and the same question: the question of how to overcome separateness, how to achieve union, how to transcend one's own individual life and find atonement. The question is the same for primitive man living in caves, for the nomadic shepherd tending his flocks, for the peasant in Egypt, the Phoenician trader, the Roman soldier, the medieval monk, the Japanese samurai, the modern clerk and factory worker. The question is one and the same, for it springs from one and the same ground: the human situation, the conditions of human existence.

The Art of Loving, pp. 17–19

Since this is the question, the most foundational distress of a person's life, every person also chooses — and, in fact, is pushed and forced to choose — some particular kind of solution, some particular way to blunt separateness and find union. The history of human culture, religion and philosophy is, in effect, the story of humanity's search for the best, the most

satisfying way of solving this. Fromm goes on to describe the foundational ways in which mature humanity, which has been gradually weaned from the symbiotic unity with nature that existed at its birth, seeks to be delivered from existential separateness:

1. Orgiastic states: one possibility of escaping separateness is by means of a repeated recourse to an intense, all-encompassing temporary experience that seizes consciousness and sensation, and neutralizes every feeling apart from it. This includes orgies, trance states, the use of drugs and alcohol, sexual experiences, and so forth. What all of these share is that they bring the body and the soul into a kind of bubble of pleasure and fusion that makes the world disappear, for a short and focused span of time. The experience, because of its intensity and vividness, dissipates entirely only after some time, and thereby it enables a stretch of time in which life is devoid of the suffering of separateness, until, little by little, the tension of anxiety and loneliness intensifies again and the person is pushed to repeat the experience. The collective orgy, insofar as it is an accepted part of tribal custom, is a reasonable solution to the problem of separateness, since it involves identification and bonding with the group and with its values and norms, and it does not arouse feelings of guilt and shame. By contrast, attachment to alcohol and drugs, and likewise the attempt of individuals to return to orgiastic states within a culture in which these are no longer acceptable, arouse the distress of separateness all the more, because of the sense of isolation and illegitimacy at the moment the experience fades. Similarly, the pursuit of sex leads to an intensification of the sense of loneliness, owing to the fact that sexuality without love fails to bridge the gap between two people except for an hour. Thus we find people caught in a cycle of this kind of addiction, in which the intensifying distress of separateness pushes them to repeat the temporary solution with growing frequency and intensity, which in turn intensify the distress, and so on.

2. Social conformity: a further way of escaping separateness is conformity — the adoption of the customs, values and deeds accepted in the society in which the person lives. Living within the framework of a collective in which there is a decisive similarity among the various individuals — in their way of life, their beliefs, their spiritual discourse, their culture, their role models, and so on — is a harmonious life, which soothes the anxiety arising from the recognition that one is an individual, special and distinct, a one-time phenomenon essentially different from everything else. Conformism protects us from singularity. The advantages of the conformity solution are constancy and continuity. On the other hand, this solution has serious problems, both because it is a factor of uniformization and of the loss of the self, of the forgetting of uniqueness and authenticity, and because it is not powerful enough to seize the whole of the person into a true experience of unity, and so is often not sufficient to soothe separateness.

3. The act of creation: in every kind of creative work, the creating person unites with the material, which symbolizes the world outside him. Therefore, every productive labor brings us to love our own handiwork, and to a heightened sense of fusion, of taste, of reward for our toil. The shortcoming is that this fusion is not interpersonal, and therefore it is not sufficient to fill the whole of our human being with a sense of unity.

Against all these, Fromm proposes love as the mature and perfect solution toward which the human being should strive. Love, indeed, has many faces and various forms, and a considerable portion of these are distorted or, to a great degree, pathological. In his book, Fromm strives to teach the correct way to love, a way that requires skill and learning like any art, so as not to stray into the fallen channels of love, such as dependent love, domineering love, narcissistic love, and so on. Love in its healthy and balanced form is bound up with an activity of giving, with concern, with responsibility and with an attitude of respect. Only in this love, according to Fromm, can one find union in the full and refined sense; only in this love are we delivered from the distress of existential separateness.

Although I feel a deep identification with Fromm's description of the distress of separateness, it seems that the expectation that the bonds of love between a person and his environment — family, friends, a spouse — will fill what is lacking and bring us to harmony and wholeness, is an excessive and overly optimistic expectation. The interpersonal path for breaking out of the self is a highly significant path, perhaps the most significant of all; but the soul is composed of further dimensions, it holds longings, drives and strivings that touch other strata of existence. A person will not be satisfied merely by mending his social bonds, even if he learns to love everyone and to devote himself to this love with a full and courageous heart. What is described as "the distress of separateness" should be grasped as one central and important manifestation of the root of all human discontent — transcendence.

3. The Search for Meaning — Viktor Frankl

Viktor Frankl is the founder of a psychological method called "logotherapy." The central claims underlying this method concern the narrow scope of relation of psychoanalysis, and the fact that the latter excelled at delving into the hidden, unconscious forces and motives underlying the psyche and human conduct, but did not devote enough attention to the world of the "logos" within a person, to the foundations of awareness and consciousness in the background of life. Logotherapy identifies a kind of neurosis that did not receive fitting treatment in the earlier psychoanalytic methods, "noogenic neurosis," which is connected not to repressions and traumas accumulating in the subconscious, but to an unfitting cognitive and spiritual approach toward life, reality and the self.

Frankl argues that the most common psychological distress, at least in the context of modern life — to the point of being defined as a "mass neurosis"[18] — is the existential vacuum, arising from a sense of the absence of meaning in life. The overt symptoms of the existential vacuum are depression, aggression and addiction,[19] but subtler symptoms arise as well. The striving for meaning is not a sign of illness, but, on the contrary — it is the most basic need of the natural spiritual character of the human soul. When the search for meaning does not find its satisfaction, and the person fails to find sense in his life, this leads to various psychic problems, and especially to a sense of distress, emptiness and desolation. Beyond this, the sense of meaning has survival value — in extreme states such as captivity or concentration camps, the prisoners who felt that there was something, or someone,

waiting for them, for whose sake they suffered and survived, had the greatest chances of being rescued.[20]

In what can one find meaning for life? What within our lives grants us the feeling that it is worth living them?

It seems to me that if we try to survey the common, prevalent and simple answers to these questions, we arrive at all sorts of different directions. Some will say, my creative work, my art, my productivity; I have no stronger sense of meaning than in the hours when I create worlds and bring them into reality, and all my hours rest on this feeling. Some will say, my children, into whom I invest all my energy and strength, my money and my time, whom I care for with a heart full of love and responsibility; they are what will remain here after me, they are what will remain of me and of my life, they are the meaning of my life, for their sake and on their behalf I act. Some will point to their religious faith — the meaning of my life is deciphered through responsiveness to the religious command, out of the anticipation of spiritual reward after death, or out of trust in the absolute obligation placed upon the human being to respond to God's call to him. Some live their lives out of great devotion to some ideal or vision, to some general value that calls upon them to devote the bulk of their energy and attention to its actualization, its advancement, its realization in the world; in this devotion, which makes their lives look markedly different from ordinary, small and self-interested lives, they find the special flavor of their lives, their purpose. Can one find a definition that expresses the common denominator of all the "meanings" a person finds for his life?

In this context Frankl coins the phrase "self-transcendence." [21] Meaning dwells in the place where a person abandons his orientation toward himself, toward the pursuit of pleasure and the chasing of happiness, and sets some goal or purpose that is transcendent to him. Whether this is concern for a person who is other than himself, whether it is the begetting of something of myself in the actual reality beyond me, whether it is devotion to a value whose benefit pertains to something other than myself. Meaning, in its essence, is a demanding matter, and it places responsibility on the person to actualize it. Demandingness and responsibility are essential in order for meaning to possess objective qualities, for otherwise the person is not, after all, rescued by it from the existential vacuum, and returns to sink into the chaos of his solipsistic world. What grants the sense of meaning is that there is a calling voice, that the "I" moves toward something other than itself, that conscience commands and the person acts as one called and choosing, and not as one merely driven. [22]

One can, then, generalize and say that when we say a person is searching for meaning, we are, in effect, saying that a person is searching to transcend.

Let us continue to unpack and illustrate the manifestations of transcendence at a higher resolution, in more focused contexts, so that the phenomenon becomes clear beyond its general-theoretical lines, and so that we can see its branches and offshoots in life itself.

4. The New and the Boring

One of the distinctive phenomena of the human type is boredom. In an existence explained on the basis of the principle of "homeostasis" — that is, the drive to reach material balance and release from internal-bodily pressures arising from unactualized drives — boredom cannot be explained. As a counter-example to the theory according to which the foundational striving of a person is to be released from tension, born of a conflict between various physiological and psychological motives, boredom comes and proves the opposite — within a person there is a basic need for a certain level of tension, or for a repeated oscillation between the accumulation of tension and its release.

Even without entering into the full depth of the matter, and without putting my head between the mountains of various psychoanalytic theories, boredom clearly shows us a simple point — a person needs novelty. When nothing new happens in life, when the things we encounter and experience tend to repeat themselves and to look as they looked yesterday, we feel distress; something of the pleasure of natural existence dims, its sting is removed. It seems that an inseparable part of the taste of life is bound to life's virtue of surprising us, of bringing us something new, of carrying on its wings something that was not there before. I wish to propose an explanation for this need for novelty by means of the concept of transcendence.

A person, at every given moment, meets the world, and this meeting is an event; there is something magical, surprising, moving about it. The very encounter, the very entry of a certain portion of reality into a person's awareness and consciousness, arouses in the person a special vitality, a certain reality of existence.[23] This effect occurs at various levels of intensity and excitement, and one of the central criteria determining the intensity of the feeling and the vitality of the encounter is the level of novelty of the thing relative to the person's world. When a person encounters something for the first time, his consciousness takes hold of the thing and surrounds it, analyzes and classifies it, measures and defines it, and finally creates for it cognitive patterns that match it, by means of which consciousness relates to the thing. The next time the person encounters that same thing, or a "thing" belonging to the same "kind" of things, such that the similarity between them is decisive, consciousness will not need to act as intensively as the first time. The thing will be grasped and catalogued by those patterns already formed, and the person's consciousness will be able to direct its energy resources to other activities. Accordingly, the event will be less meaningful, less exciting and vitalizing. In short, our familiarity with a thing dulls the feeling in encountering it.

One sees this point strikingly in children, or, more precisely, in the gap between how we adults respond to things and how children respond. It seems that children respond to everything more intensely — a silly face will make them roll with laughter, an airplane in the sky will fill them with excited enthusiasm, a small insult will make them burst into tears. Every feeling and every new object they come into contact with seizes the whole of them; they encounter it with far greater intensity and vitality. It turns out that while our cognitive

world is already rich and comprehensive, and capable of understanding any phenomenon immediately in light of prior experience and knowledge, children do not yet have developed mechanisms of identification and definition to mediate between them and their experience of the world; they encounter the thing directly, the thing as it is, in its objectivity and absoluteness.

In other words, the enchantment of a thing we encounter is rooted in its dimension of "otherness," and this fades once consciousness has grown accustomed to it. The power of the new lies in its being foreign, in its being alien to the cognitive apparatus. The more that what I encounter outside, in life in the world, is "me" — that is, the more it matches the inner cognitive patterns my consciousness has already long since formed — the more life "bores" me, that is, its flavor weakens and its vitality dissolves. By contrast, the new brings into my territory something else, something that, at least in the initial experience of the encounter, is outside me, and thereby the soul shakes itself off, revives and is refreshed.

5. A Good Name is Better than Precious Ointment

The Torah shows interest in a person's striving to leave a mark upon reality. In the language of Scripture, this mark is called a "name": "His remembrance is lost from the earth, and he has no name abroad" (Job 18:17). A person cannot bear the thought that the short span allotted to his life constitutes the whole of his being, and he must, in some form, take hold of eternity, of collective memory, of history. Things that will be called by the name of the deceased, and that will continue to exist after him, will constitute an ongoing and continuing echo of his memory, and thereby his life will have received a meaning that goes beyond a mere episode. The Torah relates to this human need to leave one's name in the world, and gives the matter expression in several passages:

And they said one to another: Come, let us make brick, and burn them thoroughly. And they had brick for stone, and slime had they for mortar. And they said: Come, let us build us a city, and a tower, with its top in heaven, and let us make us a name, lest we be scattered abroad upon the face of the whole earth.

Genesis 11:3–4

If brothers dwell together, and one of them die, and have no child, the wife of the dead shall not be married abroad unto one not of his kin; her husband's brother shall go in unto her, and take her to him as wife, and perform the duty of a husband's brother unto her. And it shall be, that the firstborn that she bears shall stand in the name of his brother that is dead, that his name not be blotted out of Israel. And if the man do not wish to take his brother's wife, then his brother's wife shall go up to the gate unto the elders, and say: My husband's brother refuses to raise up unto his brother a name in Israel, he will not perform the duty of a husband's brother unto me [...]

Deuteronomy 25:5–7

Then Boaz said unto the elders, and unto all the people: You are witnesses this day, that I have bought all that was Elimelech's, and all that was Chilion's and Mahlon's, of the

hand of Naomi. Moreover, Ruth the Moabitess, the wife of Mahlon, have I acquired to be my wife, to raise up the name of the dead upon his inheritance, that the name of the dead be not cut off from among his brethren, and from the gate of his place; you are witnesses this day.

Ruth 4:9–10

Neither let the son of the stranger, that has joined himself to the LORD, speak, saying: The LORD will surely separate me from His people; neither let the eunuch say: Behold, I am a dry tree. For thus says the LORD unto the eunuchs that keep My sabbaths, and choose the things that please Me, and hold fast by My covenant: Even unto them will I give in My house and within My walls a monument and a memorial better than sons and daughters; I will give them an everlasting name, that shall not be cut off.

Isaiah 56:3–5

The primary sense of a person's "name" is the trace he leaves in the consciousness of other human beings, his figure and worth in the eyes of human society. Some acquire a name through special deeds that distinguish them from other people — "They were the mighty men of old, men of name" (Gen. 6:4); "The memory of the righteous is for blessing, and the name of the wicked shall rot" (Prov. 10:7). From these verses it emerges that the natural and normative way of leaving a name, of securing one's memory forever, is through the begetting of children, and, in the most preferred form, the begetting of sons who will inherit you and live on your estate, an estate called by your name and by the names of your fathers. These sons will continue the chain of generations, will live and die on that same land remembered as belonging to you, and will bequeath to their sons after them the whole accumulated inheritance and heritage of your family. Thus, according to the Torah's conception, a person lies down in peace, knowing that his name has not been blotted out and his memory has not been lost from the earth, that his temporary existence had consequences for what happens on the earth in the ever-continuing present — "a generation goes and a generation comes, but the earth stands forever" (Eccl. 1:4).

The source of the feeling that my life is worth nothing if I have not left traces of memory in the world is not found in orderly, logical thought. This is a primal intuition, based on the drive of transcendence, on the need for our lives to be bound to something that is outside and beyond them. The objectivity of the world outside stands in essential opposition to the uprooted subjectivity of life, and the "I" seeks rescue by clinging to that objective reality, to be delivered from the temporary, self-enclosed chaos, and to bind itself into the bundle of life. Both the search for eternity and the search for honor and social recognition rest, at their foundation, on the longing for the objectification of existence, which is a manifestation of another kind of transcendence.

6. The Altruistic Impulse

From a certain point of view, it seems that one of the human phenomena hardest to explain is altruism. What makes a person exert himself and devote himself to the good of the

collective when this comes at the expense of his own private good? What does he "gain" from this? There are those for whom this "difficulty," or, more precisely, the worldview and starting assumptions on which it rests, has led to a conception according to which there is no person and no action driven by non-egoistic motives at all.[24] Even though we are always able to find, within ourselves, egoistic motives mixed into altruistic acts, acts intended for the good of the collective and bringing us, simply, no visible benefit at all seem to make this conclusion a denial of reality. We recognize within ourselves the intensity of the light and the fervor that fill our hearts at the thought of doing good for other people, pure kindness with no motive of gain. From a somewhat different angle, anyone who has taken part in public activity for the sake of the collective[25] knows the special power of this devotion, the vitality and the intense feeling it engenders within us, the satisfaction and the good feeling.

Within us there is an altruistic impulse. In certain, special people, this "impulse" finds expression in a more extreme way — people who are willing to sacrifice their time, their money, their strength — and, in extraordinary times, even their lives — purely for the good of the collective, for the state or the public, the world or the nation. But the basic force exists within all of us, even if we choose to set other strivings and wills against it, and, in the final reckoning, to be generally more oriented toward the actualization of our own personal goals. This force, too, is a product of transcendence. In every action whose purpose exceeds the bounds of self-interest, we feel a bond to something larger, something beyond us that grants us solidity and existence. The orientation toward the good of one who is outside me, and, at a higher level, toward the good of the collective as a whole, opens up existence and prevents it from withering and rotting within itself.

7. Man, Creator of the Gods

An inseparable part of all ancient cultures were religions and gods. The gods were given concrete form through statues and images, and yet the basic cultural consciousness that created these statues saw in them only some symbolic embodiment of the figure of a god, who is more abstract than the statue itself, and only present in it or symbolized by it. The gods were endowed with many human traits — anger and appeasement, reason (though not unlimited reason), place and time, will and feeling, and so on. What chiefly distinguishes them from the human type is their ability to control what occurs in the natural world — there is a god of rain, a god of fertility, a goddess of the earth, and so on, and each of them has the power to determine what will occur in his domain on earth. The fact that we find gods and the worship of gods in every ancient culture necessarily teaches us of a basic drive within a person to invent and create gods. How can this drive be explained? What is its source?

Science: from the more outer chambers of the soul, one can explain the creation of the gods as arising from the human need to understand and explain the world. In the age of myth, the god (or the system of gods) filled the place of scientific theories. A person experiences natural phenomena; the world before him behaves sometimes one way and sometimes

another. As long as there is no way to organize this experience and to name the causes driving the natural world to act this way or that, the world is like a closed code, like chaos devoid of logic, like a mumbling in an unfamiliar tongue. Ancient man used gods in order to explain reality and to arrange it according to a limited number of cognitive patterns, so that it would be possible to relate to it rationally. When they wished, for example, to explain rain, they described the existence of a "god of rain," a force in the world responsible for the falling of rain.

The description of religiosity as growing out of the "scientific drive" seems inadequate. It is hard to explain the critical weight, the levels of emotion and sacrifice invested in religions and in the worship of gods, purely on the basis of a claim about the cognitive nature of man. Hence, one must seek the hidden engine of the creation of the gods in more inward psychic planes.

Dread: beyond the problem of intellectual incomprehension, ancient man was a victim of an acute existential distress in the face of the surrounding natural world, which was hostile and dangerous. Man was entirely exposed to the hazards of nature — wild beasts, wind and rain, heat and cold, disease and death — with very few means of coping adequately with these. This unavoidable confrontation produced within man an intense feeling of dread. Beyond simple fear of death and suffering, one can see this dread as resting upon two further experiences: loneliness and helplessness. Loneliness is the feeling of one who stands in an empty world, a world in which, apart from the small handful of human society he knows, there is no other living soul to communicate with, to be commanded alongside, to relate to and to receive relation from. Helplessness stems from a person's inability to determine his fate, his lack of control over what happens, over the character of his future. Standing alone against the hazards of nature, against a world tossed about like a ship without rest and without a captain, filled man (and especially the technology-lacking man) with trembling and shaking, a paralysis that does not allow for life. In order to soften these distresses, human beings pictured the forces of nature as gods — that is, as bearing personal characteristics, as entities one could communicate with in some way, and, above all, worship, so that they would show mercy and grant protection and abundance. Further entities bearing the burden of responsibility for the world and for humanity ease the trembling, and from this a person is pushed to hold, with all his strength, to faith in these gods and to devotion to this faith.

We find, then, that the deepest source of the phenomenon of religiosity — a phenomenon that, in the annals of the world, has earned a place of honor as one of the central pillars of human culture — is an experience that can be called "cosmic loneliness." A person needs a face to live opposite, to worship, to fear and to love. Existence is unbearable if there is no foreign point of view looking upon it and granting it reality. Without such a face, without this interaction with a distinct factor that wants the world or at least responds to what occurs within it, it is hard to experience life as worth living and worth enduring. A picture of the world in which there are further personal factors acting on this field of the turbulent, tossed-about world grants a person the capacity to stand against this world, even before the

possibilities that open up of appeasing the forces of nature to his benefit — by the very fact that he is not alone, by the very fact that what happens here matters to someone else, by the very fact that there is here a story with meaning, a story that can be told to someone, that is not merely a nightmarish delusion within my inner world. The invention of idol worship is secondary to, and comes after, the invention of the gods; I need their existence as entities possessing consciousness and will even before I make use of various cultic techniques in order to manipulate their will to my benefit. Something within a person, then, murmurs and bubbles and seeks an external and foreign point of support to live opposite and in relation to. The religious drive rests entirely upon transcendence.

8. The Soul's Longing for Its Source

Up to this point we have painted and explained transcendence from a psychic-psychological point of view, one that seeks to see the overt behavioral or emotional actualization of the foundational psychic forces. We have seen various pictures drawn from human existence, and I have sought to point to a hidden, foundational element, and to argue for its deep involvement in the creation of all these phenomena, needs and wants. In order to complete our understanding, I wish to explain the force of transcendence from a different point of view, the metaphysical point of view.[26]

God breathed into man a soul of life from His own nostrils, and created him in His own image. The soul is truly the lamp of God, and therefore it stands, in its divine purity, throughout all its days. The soul is hewn from God, sawn off from Him in a painful, wounding process, and therefore it is bound to Him by a firm ontological bond. The soul's supreme delight is devotion (deveikut) to God, a return to union and immersion within Him, and its great pain is the pain of severance from Him. The grief of separation from the divine is the greatest suffering the soul can know; it is the very fire of Gehinnom. At the root of a person there is an unceasing running toward God, and attachment to Him is the source of all feelings of vitality, delight, touch, taste, will and good.

Where does the soul find the God it pursues? Toward which channels in life does the longing for devotion to the light of God lead it, and where does it succeed in finding this devotion? God reveals to us that He appears in everything, in everything He created in the world — "the whole earth is full of His glory." And yet, divinity gathers and reveals itself all the more in certain manifestations; there is a hierarchy among different levels of divine revelation. Theology and religion are occupied, at every step they take, with the question of what those places are in which the divine presence is greater, in which world-manifestations one should identify divinity in a more distinct and powerful way. When we survey the places that express divine revelation in a special way, we discover that these overlap with the very objects we have pointed to so far as the objects of human striving.

Man, as noted, seeks the companionship and closeness of other human beings; God, for His part, appears in a way that has no parallel among human beings, "for in the image of God made He man." Man seeks sense, purpose for his life, purpose for reality; God creates the world and man with a direction and a purpose rooted in His name and His manifestation,

"for He created all things for His glory." Man strives to be anchored in the eternal and in unconditional existence; God is described as the creator of time and as standing above it, as the necessary being, "I Will Be That I Will Be." A person's soul goes out in devotion to the collective, or to non-egoistic moral ideals; in nationhood we find the revelation of God's Shekhinah, and in ideals — the revelation of His attributes.

If we generalize the view, one can say that, for the human soul, God appears in every single thing that is outside it. A person is born, a soul is cast into him, and wherever he turns, the soul presses and pushes him toward an encounter with God, toward taking hold of and attaching himself to some manifestation, embodiment, or revelation of that abstract sought-for thing toward which it strives by its very nature. And although all the "foreign" things a person encounters in the world — when his eyes are open and his heart is sensitive — arouse in him wonder and excitement, closeness and curiosity, there are, nonetheless, territories that draw the heart more strongly, there are places in which God's presence is deeper, clearer, and the human soul recognizes them and pursues them with all its strength.

From this point of view we may say that transcendence, in its entirety, is an embodiment of the natural search for God rooted in the human soul. Because of the vital distinction between creature and Creator, because of the foundational law above, according to which God is revealed — in the soul's eyes — only in what lies outside the bounds of the "I," the longing for God translates, in our world, into a comprehensive drive toward the outside, toward attachment to every powerful and real portion of being that is not steeped in my own world. The sawing-off, and the soul's rooted nature that strives to return to its Creator-source, are the explanation of the force of transcendence within the soul.

Closing

1. Interim Summary

We have traveled a long journey, along two parallel tracks. In the two parts of the essay thus far, I have pointed to two foundational strivings — each in its turn — that nest in the inner chambers of the human heart and drive its conduct. In each part I presented a particular striving, and tried to bind to it as many behaviors, complexes, tendencies and psychic processes as possible, in order to establish its standing as a "foundational striving." In the first part I presented the striving for fullness — the psychic need for inner stability and a sense of self-wholeness that is "closed," that sets a person on his own two feet without reliance and dependency on anything outside him. We saw that many of our problems and complexes grow in the clearings left in the forest of our self-fullness, the places where we do not believe in our ability to feel worth and happiness from within ourselves, from who we choose to be and how we choose to live, the childish places where we still expect these to come from another source, from someone or something. In the second part I presented the drive of transcendence — the ceaseless psychic demand to attach oneself to some other that lies outside me, to bind my life to something whose existence is not a natural part of my own existence. Quite a few behaviors, strivings and wills that occupy a considerable place in

our lives were explained as transformations of this foundational energy, forever murmuring and surging within us, and directed outward.

Is a picture of the world in which two vectors, opposite in direction, explain most[27] of our behaviors and wills a false picture of the world? Does the sharp contrast between the two parts of the essay indicate a contradiction, or a sleight of hand? It is possible that the initial feeling, when one first thinks about this, is indeed of this kind.[28] It is the nature of thought that, once it has been persuaded of the importance and centrality of one direction, it finds it hard to accept, at the same time, the importance and centrality of the opposite direction; and if it has separately been persuaded of the importance of each of the directions, and discovers that these are opposite directions, it casts doubt on the reliability of the whole picture. However, it seems to me that if one looks at the matter clearly, this is not really a contradiction. One can, and indeed should, picture a soul with two supreme focal points, each of which pushes and pulls in a different and opposite direction, and yet it is a single soul.

2. The Dance

In order to explain and settle the matter in our minds, let us turn to observe the way of interpersonal relationships.

Every bond with another person, and especially an intimate and significant bond, requires the delicate dance between the two tendencies described. In attaching ourselves to another, we try to step out of ourselves and to preserve our own selfhood at one and the same time; at times we feel our own dissatisfaction with ourselves, and at times we feel the need for an inner harbor that will rescue us from dependency. The soul empties itself, seeks closeness and warmth, to embrace and to be embraced; but the posture of embrace is necessarily temporary, and in becoming fixed in it we feel discomfort, suffocation. One who, at the end of an episode of intense closeness, does not feel the desire to part, to breathe and to stand on his own, is as unusual as one who does not feel the desire to draw close at all. Love, in its healthy form, leaves us whole with ourselves, satisfied in our being; even though there is delight in the movement of drawing close and merging, there is also satiety. Love is not the loss of identity, for one who loses his identity in his love is unable to be part of the harmonious system of love, which always stands on two feet, in which there is an I facing a you, face to face.

Let us illustrate this from the religious context. God — the end and the beginning of the ladder of love within our soul — plays, for His part, this very same game with us, dances for us this dance of love. He leaves the world close enough to Him that we can be exposed to Him and long for Him, yet far enough that we not be swallowed and lost within His light. He opens, within our reality, chinks toward the divine reality beyond, but maintains a partial concealment of His face, in order to leave in our hands the choice and the possibility of turning our faces away from Him. And we too, deep within our souls, are attuned to that same rhythm; in the very inclination of our spirit there is that same melody of forward and backward, of running and returning. We seek our God, but we do not come unto Him, "for

man shall not see Me and live." And our lives are full of a circular movement of balance between longing and running toward divinity, on the one hand, and the growth and sustenance of life, on the other, between holiness, prayer and inspiration, on the one hand, and repairing the world and serving through the material, on the other.[29]

One can use this model to grasp, clearly and comprehensively, the very general subject of our concern in this essay — the relationship between a person and what lies outside him. That same dance found within every relationship — foremost among them our relationship with those we love, and, at its foundation, our attachment to God, blessed be He — is, in fact, if one may put it this way, among the most foundational movements in our existential lives. At times we are pushed and drawn outward, while what we truly need is to establish our own standing; at times we remain clinging to our inner circle, while what we truly need is to answer our deep thirst to break out, to transcend and to attach. Sometimes we go out from ourselves in exactly the right measure and place, and sometimes we overdo it. The sketch we have set out in this essay, and the talk of the need for inner listening, balance and precision, do not give a formula or a solution to these questions of life; they do not constitute a recipe for a good and whole life. My hope, however, is that they provide concepts, clarity and insight that assist in this work.

3. The Transcendence within Fullness and the Fullness within Transcendence

It seems that, upon closer observation, it becomes clear not only that these two foundational axes of the soul complement one another, joining together into the foundational rhythm of the pulse of life, but that they are also bound up with one another, in the sense that each plays an important role in the being of the other.

A person's responsiveness to transcendence — his readiness to devote himself to values or to people, his constant extraction of himself from boredom, from materialism and from self-centeredness, toward spiritual-moral movement — is itself what grants a person one of the vital foundations of fullness, which we defined above as purpose. Fullness, as noted, requires a consciousness that life has a direction toward which I want to take it, that I have some "what" to do that carries sense, while breaking out from the self is the only possibility for such a sense to exist. "Transcendent" activity, or at least a consciousness of such activity as the content of life, is therefore a necessary component in the picture of a soul that has fullness.

From the other side, the soul requires a certain measure of fullness in order to be rescued from being swept away by transcendence outward. Something within a person constantly pushes him to step outside himself, to break out, not to be content with what already exists within him; and without there being, alongside this natural drive, also some solid consciousness of inner wholeness and of dependency-free self-love, and a capacity to rest in the shade of this consciousness, the person will feel placeless, wandering and drifting; and when there is no anchor from which to set out, devotion goes on to become assimilation,

ruin, an empty frenzy. What grants the delight of stepping outside the self toward an other, and the whole weight of meaning and psychic nourishment in this movement, is the fact that I have a home that I am leaving, that I have an "I" from which I meet a "you," and into which I bring new guests. Inner stability, fullness, is what will determine whether following transcendence will be an outpouring or a draining, whether it will be a blessing or a flight.

* * *

Notes

1. I declare my own presumptuousness openly and with exaggerated sobriety, in order to achieve two different, complementary effects: the first, that the very declaration of this will count, for me, as a kind of apology, which is a traditional and almost obligatory component of essays of this kind. In this I try to distance from myself the antagonistic, cynical but essentially fair reaction of those whose ears automatically close before presumptuousness that is not aware of itself. The second, the declaration is meant precisely in order to put on the table the scope of the argument, which seriously attempts to relate to a very broad range of experiences and sides of the soul, and to focus them around two foundational axes. For I believe there is benefit, in such a comprehensive outlook, of simplification, clarification and self-understanding.

Nevertheless, out of necessity, a few words of qualification: in this essay I propose a certain point of view on the life of the soul, which is presumably complex and rich beyond measure. My words should not be seen as an exclusive proposal, and I do not necessarily come to exclude different, and even opposite, points of view on those same psychic processes, wills and complexes that I will explain and elucidate in what follows. In the soul, only a multiplicity of points of view can bring us closer to the truth, to full understanding (which does not exist). It is clear that one cannot fit the vast richness of psychic existence into rigid frameworks — however inward and deep they may be — and therefore the scope of the phenomena I will address in what follows is also, by its nature, limited.

2. What I call, in this essay, "fullness," I have found, with a great, near-complete overlap, in other places under different names. In the essay "On Honor and Loneliness" by Amichai Friedman — on which a considerable part of this essay is based, and from which it draws — the concept parallel to "fullness" is the concept of "honor" (Amichai Friedman, "On Honor and Loneliness," in: Petichta 1, published by Yeshivat Hesder Petach Tikva). In Mordechai Gafni's book Soul Prints, the parallel concept is "certainty," in the sense of self-certainty.

3. The possibility of establishing the sense of self-worth in a conscious and chosen way, by means of foundational beliefs and inner reflection, is important for two reasons. The first reason is to enable psychic health and fullness for one whose fate was not kind and who did not grow up under optimal conditions. The second reason concerns all human beings: even one who was indeed born into an optimal family environment (to the extent such a thing exists) — loving, nurturing and devoted parents — often needs a further source for grounding his sense of worth. The more a person matures, the more reflective he becomes, and the more reflective he is, the more critical he becomes toward himself and toward the impressions instilled in him, even if these are positive impressions, such as the unconditional worth he received from his parents-progenitors. Awareness has the power to wear down and thin out even our deepest psychic impressions. Therefore we cannot rely only on these, and we must direct awareness itself along the correct paths if we wish to reach some psychic destination and live it out stably and validly. Autonomous recognition, when it deals with the matter of a person's worth and exclusivity, empowers the sense

of self-worth and channels into it forces of a different kind, ones that could not be found from an instilled, external and non-elective source.

4. One can encounter this movement, for example, in youths strong in spirit, who succeeded in preserving their health and sanity while being taunted by the surrounding society, which was genuinely more talented than they were in the measured domains. Like that one kid in the class who is truly bad at soccer, but nevertheless does not refrain from going onto the playing field and trying again, and even enjoying the game. In the common, unhealthy state, that same one who does not receive his self-approval from his environment, one who truly is not successful by the standards his environment chooses in order to "rank" socially those within its circle (standards such as athleticism or a sense of humor, as common examples in youth societies), turns to one of three complex-tracks: either he withdraws from society and folds into himself, whether in resentment and self-flagellation over his lack of success and his isolation, or by creating a barrier of indifference and numbness to everything occurring on the social plane; or he continues to try to prove himself in the game of soccer from a position of inferiority, and fills with self-anger and shame at every failure in this domain; or he dons an armor of displayed self-confidence, which is usually visibly false and brittle, and continues to take part in the social game while shutting his eyes from seeing the social rejection directed at him and his lack of talent, an eye-shutting that, depending on the need, can be performed with surprising success. And yet, one can also encounter a healthy way of coping: a youth who, though not entirely indifferent to what is said and thought about him in the surrounding society, and though he would like to be talented at soccer and is well aware of the fact that he is not, nevertheless decides to produce for himself a basis of genuine self-confidence, which enables him to stand and exist within the social environment. He accepts himself and his weakness without qualification, and builds his fortress around this powerful self-acceptance, to the point that it does not bother him to keep playing, and failing, and yet enjoy the game to some degree. As a result of his courageous choice to accept himself despite his weaknesses and to be whole with what he is, he manages to absorb the failures and the rejection with a certain kind of distance, as though these pertain only to some outer shell of his and not to the very self within, and, inwardly, he remains happy with himself and loves his life.

The psychic movement described requires a certain refinement so as not to turn into a crude and false movement. We will discuss this when we touch on the concept of humility below.

5. The picture of members of a cult who follow, blindly, a charismatic, forceful and domineering guru is, as noted, an extreme picture. But it seems to me one can see soft shades of the phenomenon in more common territories. It is hard to sketch this precisely, but it seems to me that in some of the places where a person abandons his autonomous stance, and gives up his own independent judgment and criticism in favor of following a social-value movement and the ready-made, well-defined system of values it offers him, we are dealing with a phenomenon of this kind. I stress that this is true of some of these cases, since this movement of belonging and casting one's lot (in the value-ideological sense) can also be done from a healthy place. The point of distinction, in my view, is the question of self-awareness of the process. The more a person is aware that, at the basis of his unconditional joining of this circle that obligates him, lies his own elective decision as an independent, worthy creature, the more the casting of one's lot is a deliberate, reasonable and healthy movement. By contrast, if the strong pull toward the "movement" reality — a pull born of the power of the "purpose" it grants the person, even at the expense of manifestations of "worth," of uniqueness and autonomy — blinds his eyes to the point that, inwardly, he feels there is no other possibility, then, in such a state, "worth" is truly harmed. Such a person does not attain fullness.

6. On the foundational nature of this movement of withdrawal, see Rav J. B. Soloveitchik, "Tzeruf," in: *Divrei Hagut Ve-Ha'arakhah*, pp. 239–254.

7. Balat"am = an acronym in military slang for "not planned"; an unforeseen event that disrupts the order of things.

8. I spoke above of the psychic stance that says "it is good for me to be with who I am, as I am." In order to complete this stance into a healthy, comprehensive self-relation, one must join humility to it, and this by means of a fine but critical distinction between important and essential, between inner and core. When I say that it is good for me to be with who I am, this is not meant to include all my feelings and all my thoughts; it is not meant to constitute an advance approval of everything I find within myself. Humility allows me to take seriously the critical thoughts I think about myself, and even to let them seep into me and shake me, and yet — precisely because of the understanding that being incomplete is part of the very definition of being human — to separate, internally, between this and the unconditional self-love and self-acceptance that form the deep core of my existence.

9. Let me illustrate my meaning: in almost every animated Disney film there is a recurring-but-changing character one could call "the villain's right-hand man" — Lefou in *Beauty and the Beast*, Iago in *Aladdin*, the hyenas in *The Lion King*, the eels in *The Little Mermaid*, Pain and Panic in *Hercules*, and more. In all its various incarnations, this character appears prominently as an "empty" figure, one with no selfhood and no honor, who is dragged along, devoting himself to the strong character and striving to please him and his worldview. True, alongside the positive heroes too one can usually find some devoted armor-bearer or loyal advisor, and indeed one can say of them (or of some of them) as well that they suffer from a dangerous lack of fullness. It seems, indeed, that one can distinguish between good leadership, which creates loyalty, appreciation and even a sense of awe at greatness, and a crushing, oppressive superiority; but, at the bottom line, alongside every kind of leadership one can find people who lose their own backbone in their devotion.

10. See Jonathan Franzen's novel *Freedom*, on the hidden power of the competitive motive in life.

11. It does not seem right to me to say that the entire competitive impulse rests on a failure to attain inner fullness (though this failure, too, is built-in, expected and natural). This is a foundational force that, when viewed in its pure form, is a positive force that leads to ambition and to running forward. One could say that what defines positive competitiveness, in my eyes, is "sportsmanship" — a state of mind in which competitiveness is grasped as a means for self-challenge and self-improvement, without this coming into conflict with feelings of love for the person we are competing against, like a loving couple who play some board game together and rejoice in the other's success even while naturally wanting to win. This is a kind of double awareness that understands that competitiveness itself is only an artificial incentive to push oneself forward, and that the real story unfolds between the person and himself.

12. Just to sharpen the understanding, let me note that one should distinguish between two kinds of failure. One kind is my failure facing myself, a weakness of will and a bad choice that bring me to despair of my own willpower and of my ability to guide my life and my character toward the goals I desire. This is a failure that leads to despair. The second kind is my lack of success facing reality or facing society, disappointment at what other people think of me, at my place in the world, or at the bitter fate that has befallen me. I am not despairing of myself as a choosing creature, but I am despairing of my ability to struggle against my difficult reality, against the circumstances of my life and against the events and experiences I undergo, which leads to surrender. Self-pity comes both from despair and from surrender, and in what I said above I try to generalize both kinds under the concept of failure, despite the significant difference between them.

13. The expression "feels emptiness" is not precise, since I am speaking here of emptiness as an essential concept, and not necessarily of a conscious, felt experience of emptiness.

14. By the concept of addiction we are accustomed to relate to a few common phenomena, such as addiction to sex, to cigarettes or to drinking, some of which are material and some mental. But it is clear that, on closer reflection, the concept includes far broader patterns, such as, for example, addiction to a forum or a website whose updates we feel a need to check every hour, or the constant watching of an endless television series "so as not to miss an episode," or any repeated behavior we perform more because we are accustomed to it than because of the satisfaction it genuinely provides in itself.

15. Or, in other words, so as not to be exposed to his own emptiness.

16. All of these are indeed different existential matters, but in what follows I will try to show that they revolve around one central point.

17. On the opposition and contradiction between the two concepts, and on the question of whether these two descriptions rule each other out or not, both theoretically and existentially, we will speak in the final part of the essay, devoted to this.

18. Viktor Frankl, *The Unheard Cry for Meaning*, Dvir, p. 23.

19. *Ibid.*, pp. 25–28; *ibid.*, pp. 110–120.

20. *Ibid.*, p. 37; and see also his *Man's Search for Meaning*, Dvir, especially the first part.

21. Viktor Frankl, *The Will to Meaning*, pp. 40–97.

22. Of the many passages one could cite from his writings, which clarify the matter from many angles, I choose the following: "Self-actualization is not man's ultimate destination. It is not even his primary intention. Self-actualization, if made an end in itself, contradicts the self-transcendent quality of human existence. Like happiness, self-actualization is an effect, the effect of meaning fulfillment. Only to the extent to which man fulfills a meaning out there in the world does he fulfill himself. If he sets out to actualize himself, rather than fulfill a meaning out there, self-actualization immediately loses its justification. I would say that self-actualization is an unintended effect of meaning fulfillment." (*The Will to Meaning*, p. 48)

23. This phenomenon also finds expression on the physiological plane. When a person is in a new environment, the stimuli are stronger, and the body enters, instinctively, into a state called the "orienting response" — a feeling of arousal, an addition of adrenaline, high muscle tension and a sharpening of the senses.

24. In the formulation of Joey, from the show *Friends*: "There is no such thing as an unselfish good deed" — that is, there is no such thing as a selfless good deed. See his argument with Phoebe, Season 5, Episode 4.

25. Especially one who has succeeded in offsetting, within himself, the impressions of power, honor and dominance found in the public sphere, or a situation in which there is not much room for such impressions, and the person acts out of purely idealistic devotion alone.

26. The metaphysical picture I will sketch is, of course, based on many assumptions and starting points that I do not intend to justify, or even to spell out explicitly. I am leaning on an accepted Jewish picture of the world, which has many sources, from the Bible and the aggadot of our Sages, through the medieval Jewish philosophers (chiefly the Neoplatonists among them), down to Kabbalah and Hasidism. The aim is not to persuade and prove the validity of the picture, but to add a layer of imaginative, legendary-mythic understanding. The metaphysical layer, even taken as a possible picture and hypothesis (albeit a credible and persuasive one) rather than as dogma, grants us a special closeness to the concepts and a deeper grasp of them, one not attainable by other means.

27. I do not insist on claiming a majority (how would one even count?). It is enough for me to have the sense that these are indeed central and foundational strivings underlying many different and varied psychic branches.

28. This recalls one of the most common arguments against Freud's psychoanalytic theory (and perhaps against any psychodynamic theory): if two opposite behaviors, such as, for example, a stingy tendency and a problem of excessive spending, are both explained by the theory by means of the very same factor (in our example, a fixation at the anal stage), this attests to some flaw in the logical coherence of the theory and in the verifiability of its claims. Though it should be noted that, in our case, we are dealing with the opposite situation, which is not symmetrical to the argument above — in what I have said, I have not proposed a single source for a given pair of opposite behaviors, but rather opposite sources for a rich and broad variety of behaviors.

29. In many senses, the good and healthy balance of inside and outside is part of the unique virtue of love. In love, the possibility opens up of giving of yourself and feeling that, in doing so, you are not draining life-forces from yourself outward, but, on the contrary, that in doing so you fill your own soul, since to the one you love, you give, and his delight delights you as well. Giving and going-beyond arise from the soul's need for devotion, but return as a lining for the sense of selfhood and a nourishment of inner wholeness. See also my essay "Le-Shem Shamayim," Petichta 14, Yeshivat Hesder Petach Tikva.